

# Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

## Chapter 13



# CHAPTER 13



DISCOVERY

Monsieur Bonnefoy hurried on deck and stood at the rail. "Ah, Bourbon!" he sighed. Then he snapped his fingers impatiently. "No, no! I must remember! Since the Revolution, all is changed! It is no longer Bourbon — cursed name of kings! It is Réunion. And I must remember to call every man Citizen! We no longer have titles. No *Monsieur*! No *Marquis*! Every man is Citizen!"

When they were still well out from shore, a pilot boat came to meet the *Henry*, and the pilot conducted them to anchorage a mile off Bourbon. Nat spoke to the man in French. When would they be allowed to enter the harbor?

The pilot shrugged and spread his hands. "There is no harbor, monsieur. The last typhoon — *pouff!* It took everything!"

Nat interpreted to Captain Prince.

Prince said, "The devil! That means we'll have to lighter the cargo."

The pilot explained the situation cheerfully. Nat translated again. "He says it will really not delay us much — having to lighter the cargo. The coffee crop is slow coming in. Even if we unloaded quickly, we'd have to wait on our return cargo. So everything is working out fine — he says."



Captain Prince said, "He still calls it Bourbon, doesn't he?"

"Yes. I asked him about that. He says the people are used to saying Bourbon. They haven't gotten around to changing yet."

Another American ship was anchored near the *Henry*. The master, Captain Blanchard, came aboard the *Henry*. He was full of questions about home and just as full of advice about how to get along in Bourbon.

"Remember the Revolution!" he said. "Call every man Citizen! Say *Vive la république!* That's what I did! And do you know what happened? Those Frenchies were so pleased that they bought my whole cargo of wine — just like that! At one thousand livres a cask!"

Prince thanked Blanchard for his advice.

"It's nothing," Blanchard said. "Glad to help you. Remember! *Vive la république!* And you'll sell your cargo in jig time!"

The next day Captain Prince, Nat, and Monsieur Bonnefoy went ashore. When they landed, Bonnefoy spoke to everyone he saw, calling loudly and cheerfully, "*Bon jour, Citoyen!*"

The people smiled, answered lazily, "*Bon jour, monsieur!*"

It didn't seem to Nat that they were worrying much about the Revolution. In fact, they didn't seem to be worrying much about anything. How slowly they moved, walking as though they had just gotten over a long illness!

Before Nat had gone far, though, he found out why people moved so lazily. They had the right idea. Brisk dashing about didn't work well in the muggy tropical heat.



They told Monsieur Bonnefoy good-by, and went to the Office of the Committee of Public Safety to get permission to land their cargo. Near the office, a man greeted them and offered his services as an interpreter. Nat was glad now that Frederic Jordy had made him learn to pronounce French. For Prince clapped his hand on Nat's shoulder and said, "We don't need an interpreter!"

Nat handled their business quickly, while Captain Prince relaxed and waited.

When business was settled, one of the Frenchmen said, "Did you hear about Captain Blanchard, monsieur?" His eyes twinkled. "He tried to impress us. He shouted, '*Vive la république!*' So — of course we were impressed.



It would have been rude not to be, eh? We offered him one thousand livres per cask for his whole cargo of wine. We bought it all, too. He didn't know . . .” For a moment the Frenchman laughed so hard he could not go on. “He didn't know that wine is so scarce it's selling for *five* thousand livres a cask!”

Nat laughed with him, then pulled a solemn face. “Citizen! I have some shoes to sell! *Vive la république!*”

The Frenchmen laughed and slapped each other on the shoulders. “You'll easily get three hundred fifty

livres for boots," they told him, "if you don't try to impress anyone!"

Nat did some rapid calculating. A livre was worth about three cents now. If he did as well on the half boots and shoes, too, he'd sell his venture for four times what he paid for it!

The next day the long, tedious business of lightering their cargo began. Some days they unloaded seventy-five casks; some days the sea was so rough that they had to cover the water with an oil slick before the boats could approach the *Henry*. Some days the rain came in torrents and they could do nothing. A whole month to lighter a cargo that could have been unloaded in days at a wharf!

Every day Johnny's face got longer. "I hope," he muttered, "it isn't going to take this long to load!"

But it did. There were days when the sun was bright and the sea was calm — and there was no coffee ready to be loaded. There were other days when a cargo waited on shore — and the rain poured down. It was September — with luck they'd have been home then — before they weighed anchor.

Nat watched the jagged outlines of Bourbon fade astern. He saw Prince's face harden into grim lines again. Why was it, he wondered. He puzzled over it, but couldn't find an answer.



Soon his days and nights settled down to a routine. As second mate, he stood watches; he was doing most of the navigating now. Everyone admitted he could shoot the sun as well as the next man, and do the figuring afterwards twice as fast. As for lunars — no one else pretended to work those calculations. Between times, Nat taught the crew, and studied the tables in Moore's book of navigation.



One night when he was working with Moore he blinked, shook his head, and stared at a figure again. That couldn't be a mistake in Moore! Moore's *Navigator* was supposed to be the best book of its kind in the world! Nat worked through the figures twice to be sure; it was an error! He was so startled that he strode into Captain Prince's cabin without knocking.

Captain Prince jumped to his feet. "What's happened?"

"I found an error in one of Moore's tables!"

Prince looked at him in utter disgust. "Is that what you came slamming in here about? An error in which table?"

Nat told him.

Prince gave a short laugh. "My dear Mr. Bowditch, Moore didn't compute that table. Do you know who did? Nevil Maskelyne, the royal astronomer of England!"

"I can't help who computed it!" Nat barked. "There's an error!" He showed Prince his page of figures. "There! I checked it! See? Why didn't Moore check those figures before he accepted them?"

Prince looked at the paper covered with Nat's tiny figures. "All that — to find one error? And there are probably two hundred thousand figures in those tables.

Maybe that's why he didn't check every figure, Mr. Bowditch."

"But he should have! Mathematics is nothing if it isn't accurate! Men's lives depend on the accuracy of those tables! It's — it's — criminal to have a mistake in a book like this! Do you hear me! It's criminal! Men's

lives depend on these figures!" Nat hadn't realized how he was shouting until he stopped. In the heavy silence he heard the *bong-bong* of the ship's bell.



Captain Prince said, "Eight bells. Your watch, Mr. Bowditch. Men's lives depend on that, too."

"Aye, aye, sir." Nat went topside. Furiously he paced the deck. Then, as suddenly as his temper blazed, he cooled off and laughed at himself. What a fool he had been to storm at Captain Prince that way. It wasn't Prince's fault there were errors in Moore's book! When he saw Prince again, he'd apologize.

All through his watch he caught himself listening for Prince's footstep or his voice. But he did not appear. When Nat's watch ended, he went below with a lantern to get his sextant. He found a note lying on the copy of Moore's book. In Prince's slashing scrawl he read:



Carry on, Mr. Bowditch! Find some more errors, and we'll beard Mr. Blunt of Newbury in his den when we get home. He's the American publisher who's going to bring out an American edition of Moore.

Nat grinned and went topside again with his sextant. Tonight ought to be a good one for a lunar. The moon was due to pass over a star that was bright enough to see in spite of its nearness to the moon. But the same thing happened that happened so many times. Just when the moon neared the bright star, a cloud got in the way. Nat shrugged and sighed. There ought to be a better way to work a lunar! He studied the glittering heavens. Was there another star bright enough tonight — that the moon would pass over? Of course not. He knew that.

That one . . . the moon would pass below it . . . that one . . . the moon would pass above it . . . that one . . .

The idea hit Nat so suddenly that he gasped. He raced below and for the second time that night crashed into Prince's cabin without knocking.

Prince was asleep, but he was on his feet in an instant. "What is it?"

"A new way to work lunars! Come on deck! As fast as you can!" He dashed out the door and up the companionway. He was on deck again before he remembered he hadn't said *sir*. When Prince joined him, Nat's words tumbled over themselves as he explained. "This business of waiting for the moon to occult a star — it's a nuisance. But what if we take the position of the moon in relation to three stars? For instance, right now, we can get the angle between —"



Captain Prince said, "Wait!" He sent for his sextant. "Mr. Collins, swing into the wind, back sail and hold steady!"

Soon they were checking lunars the new way. When they had taken several sights, they went below. Nat checked the stars in the almanac and made his computations. His method worked!

Nat glowed. "See? That's mathematics! It should give you the right answer!"

Prince sighed. "Yes, Mr. Bowditch. And now — please — no more discoveries tonight!"

"Aye, aye, sir!" Nat laughed and went topside again. He was too excited to sleep.

When the *Henry* anchored in Salem Harbor, Nat went with Captain Prince to the Custom House to declare their cargo.

As they came out, Prince laughed and clapped Nat on the back. "A good voyage, Nat!" He grinned like a boy again. "The *Henry* did well — and so did you!"

"Aye, aye, sir! Mighty well!" He had his pay, and almost five hundred dollars that he had made on his venture in shoes. And he had his new way of working lunars. Ho for the life of a sailor! he thought. He caught himself walking with a bit of a roll.

The cold of the North Atlantic, the smothering heat of the tropics, the days and nights of fighting storms — all seemed very far away now.

He saw a pudgy figure hurrying to meet them. “There’s Dr. Bentley!” He lifted his hand to wave and call, but something in the minister’s face silenced him.

Dr. Bentley said, “Nat, you must see Mary first. She needs you. David — and his crew — all died of fever.”